

— MDT —

THE DOPAMINE AUDIT · YOUR FIRST FIX

Break the Reflex

Your hand moves before you do. So make the grab harder.

WHY THIS IS THE FIGHT

The reach for the phone is not a decision, it is a reflex the device spent years training into you. Every badge, banner, and buzz is a cue, and the icon sitting on your home screen is a cue too. Reflexes do not lose to willpower, which is why "I will just check it less" never holds. You are trying to out-discipline a machine built by people whose whole job is to make you pick it up.

HOW IT WORKS

A habit runs on a loop: a cue, the grab, a hit of novelty. Kill the cue and add friction to the grab, and the loop has nothing to fire on. That is why changing your environment beats gritting your teeth, you are not resisting the urge a hundred times a day, you are removing the thing that triggers it. Out of sight really is most of the way to out of mind.

THE FIXES

Turn off every notification that is not a real person contacting you directly. Take the worst apps off your home screen so opening them takes a deliberate search. Set the screen to greyscale so it stops rewarding your eyes. And keep the phone out of the room for the bookends of the day, the first twenty minutes awake and the whole time you sleep. Buy a cheap alarm clock so you have no excuse to keep it by the bed.

SEVEN DAYS

Print this. Run the fix for a week. Circle Y or N each day, one column per day. One honest week tells you more than a month of good intentions.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Phone stayed out of reach for the first 20 minutes awake	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N
Phone slept outside arm's reach	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N	Y/N

THE EVENING CHECK

Each night: when did the urge to grab it hit hardest, and what set it off, boredom, a notification, or a feeling you did not want to sit with?

The feed will take whatever you give it. Decide what you won't.

This is the fix for the pattern your audit flagged as the tightest grip. Run it for a week before you add another. The other three are waiting when you are ready.